

India POST: India’s Parliamentary Office of Science and Technology

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Abstract

This study examines the institutional feasibility of establishing a Parliamentary Office of Science and Technology (POST) in India, modeled on the UK Parliament. As complex domains such as artificial intelligence and climate change accelerate, legislatures require independent, non-partisan technical expertise distinct from executive bodies like NITI Aayog (Jasanoff 1990; OECD 2019; IPCC 2023). By evaluating the structural gap in India’s current legislative framework, this paper argues that an independent parliamentary science office would significantly enhance the scientific grounding and adaptability of Indian legislation.

Introduction

The quality of legislation depends fundamentally on the depth and rigor of parliamentary deliberation. As scientific and technological developments accelerate, legislatures face mounting pressure to evaluate complex evidence and emerging policy vectors (Jasanoff 1990; Weingart 1999). To keep pace with rapid innovation and make technical knowledge directly accessible to India’s Parliament, the legislature could benefit from establishing its own POST, modeled after the UK Parliament (UK Parliament, n.d.). Drawing on Sheila Jasanoff’s (1990) framework of science advisors in policymaking, legislatures often struggle to independently vet technical claims without dedicated internal support. A permanent expert body would ensure that parliamentary discourse remains grounded in evidence-based analysis, mitigating the influence of unverified assumptions or technical misinformation in public administration

(Jasanoff 1990; Weingart 1999). Furthermore, because executive bodies report to the government of the day, an independent parliamentary office is essential for serving all Members of Parliament across party lines—including backbenchers and the opposition—to ensure robust legislative scrutiny.

Methodology

This study employs a conceptual institutional analysis, utilizing comparative documentation from the UK Parliament’s POST and India’s NITI Aayog, alongside established scholarship in Science and Technology Studies (STS) (Jasanoff 1990; NITI Aayog, n.d.; UK Parliament, n.d.). It evaluates structural parallels and institutional requirements to determine how a legislative science advisory body could integrate into the Indian parliamentary framework (such as under the Lok Sabha/Rajya Sabha Secretariat or existing Parliamentary Committees). Given its focus on structural comparison and institutional design, this paper does not generate primary empirical data; rather, it offers a comparative framework for legislative reform.

Discussion and Conclusion

Scientific advice for legislatures is distinct from executive policy advice because its primary purpose is to support legislative deliberation, scrutiny, and public accountability rather than to directly implement government policy (Jasanoff 1990; Weingart 1999). While NITI Aayog plays a vital role in executive strategic planning, its institutional position as a government think tank is fundamentally different from a parliamentary office serving elected representatives directly (NITI Aayog, n.d.). This structural distinction is crucial, particularly when legislation must govern rapidly evolving fields such as artificial intelligence and climate adaptation (OECD 2019; IPCC 2023).

Ultimately, the establishment of an Indian POST should not be viewed as redundant with executive bodies like NITI Aayog, but as a necessary mechanism to ensure that Parliament retains independent analytical capacity. Further research should assess the direct impact of the UK Parliament’s POST on legislative efficiency and policy outcomes to provide further

empirical backing. For India, creating a parliamentary science office remains a vital institutional step toward strengthening the scientific foundation of democratic lawmaking (Jasanoff 1990; UK Parliament, n.d.; Weingart 1999).

References

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